

OpenClaw Troubleshooting Guide

The complete fix-it guide for Hostinger VPS users

This guide covers every common problem you might run into while using OpenClaw on a Hostinger VPS. For each issue, you'll find the symptoms to look for, what causes it, and the exact steps to fix it. Every terminal command is explained in plain English so you don't need any technical background to follow along.

All commands in this guide are designed for the Hostinger Terminal. To open it, go to your Hostinger dashboard, click on your VPS, and click the **Terminal** button in the top right corner.

Quick reference — the two commands that fix most problems:

```
docker exec -it $(docker ps -aq --filter name=openclaw | head -1) openclaw doctor --fix
```

What this does: Runs OpenClaw's built-in health checker and automatically fixes common issues like permissions, missing files, and config errors.

```
docker restart $(docker ps -aq --filter name=openclaw | head -1)
```

What this does: Restarts the OpenClaw container so it picks up any changes.

If those two commands don't solve your problem, find your specific issue below.

What's In This Guide

- **Problem 1:** Agent crashed after config change (most common)
 - **Problem 2:** Agent shows 'typing' but never replies
 - **Problem 3:** Agent not responding at all (completely silent)
 - **Problem 4:** API credits ran out or rate limit hit
 - **Problem 5:** Agent not responding in Telegram groups
 - **Problem 6:** Agent stuck after restart
 - **Problem 7:** Gateway dashboard won't load
 - **Problem 8:** Skill installation failed or skill not working
 - **Problem 9:** Google Workspace (GOG) OAuth not connecting
 - **Nuclear option:** Restore from backup
 - **Prevention tips:** How to avoid problems in the future
-

Problem 1

Agent Crashed After Config Change

This most commonly happens during the **Organising Your Telegram with Groups** lesson or when your agent changes settings for voice mode, channels, or other features.

Symptoms:

- Agent stops responding completely — no replies to any messages
- `/model` and `/restart` commands don't work
- Container shows as Running in Docker Manager but nothing works

What happened:

Your agent changed a value in the config file (`openclaw.json`) to something that isn't valid. For example, it might have set `groupPolicy` to `"denylist"` when the only valid options are `"open"`, `"disabled"`, or `"allowlist"`. OpenClaw crashes immediately when it reads an invalid config.

Step 1 — Check the logs

Open the Hostinger Terminal and copy and paste this command:

```
docker logs $(docker ps -aq --filter name=openclaw | head -1) --tail 20
```

What this does: Shows the last 20 lines of output from OpenClaw. Look for **Config invalid** and **exited with code 1**.

Step 2 — See the current config

To see what your config file looks like right now, run:

```
docker exec $(docker ps -aq --filter name=openclaw | head -1) cat /data/.openclaw/openclaw.json
```

What this does: Prints the entire config file so you can see what's wrong.

Step 3 — Fix the bad value

Copy and paste the fix that matches your error:

Fix: groupPolicy has an invalid value (most common)

```
docker exec $(docker ps -aq --filter name=openclaw | head -1) sed -i 's/"groupPolicy": "[^"]*" /data/.openclaw/openclaw.json
```

What this does: Finds the groupPolicy setting and replaces whatever invalid value is there with "open". Valid options: **open**, **disabled**, **allowlist**.

Fix: dmPolicy has an invalid value

```
docker exec $(docker ps -aq --filter name=openclaw | head -1) sed -i 's/"dmPolicy": "[^"]*" /data/.openclaw/openclaw.json
```

What this does: Same idea but for the dmPolicy setting. Replaces it with "pairing". Valid options: **pairing**, **allowlist**, **open**, **disabled**.

Fix: any other invalid config value

```
docker exec -it $(docker ps -aq --filter name=openclaw | head -1) openclaw doctor --fix
```

What this does: Runs OpenClaw's built-in doctor tool which scans the entire config and auto-fixes common issues.

Step 4 — Restart and verify

After fixing the config, restart the container:

```
docker restart $(docker ps -aq --filter name=openclaw | head -1)
```

Wait a minute, then send "hello" in Telegram. If no reply, type **/new** to start a fresh session.

Problem 2

Agent Shows 'Typing' But Never Replies

Symptoms:

- You see "typing..." in Telegram but the message never arrives
- Agent seems to be thinking but eventually gives up silently

What happened:

The AI model your agent is using isn't responding. This usually happens when the model's API is slow, down, or the session is stuck.

Fix 1 — Start a new session:

Type **/new** in Telegram. This clears the current session and starts fresh. Then type "hello" to test.

Fix 2 — Switch to a different model:

Type **/model** in Telegram, then browse providers and pick a different model (like Claude Sonnet or Haiku). If **/model** doesn't respond either, try Fix 3.

Fix 3 — Change the model via terminal:

```
docker exec $(docker ps -aq --filter name=openclaw | head -1) sed -i 's/"primary": "[^"]*" / "primary": "anthropic\/claude-sonnet-4-6" /' /data/.openclaw/openclaw.json
```

What this does: Changes the primary model in the config to Claude Sonnet. Then restart:

```
docker stop $(docker ps -aq --filter name=openclaw | head -1) && docker start $(docker ps -aq --filter name=openclaw | head -1)
```

What this does: Fully stops and starts the container (more thorough than restart). Wait a minute, then type **/new** in Telegram followed by "hello".

Important: Hostinger's Docker container may not pick up config changes from a simple *docker restart*. Use *docker stop* + *docker start* instead, and always type **/new** in Telegram after to start a fresh session.

Problem 3

Agent Not Responding At All

Symptoms:

- No "typing" indicator, no response, complete silence
- Agent was working before but suddenly stopped

What happened:

The OpenClaw container might have stopped, or the gateway process inside it crashed.

Fix 1 — Check if the container is running:

Go to Hostinger → Docker Manager. Check if OpenClaw shows a green **Running** status. If it says **Stopped** or **Exited**, click the three dots and hit **Start**.

Fix 2 — Restart the container:

```
docker restart $(docker ps -aq --filter name=openclaw | head -1)
```

Wait a minute and test in Telegram.

Fix 3 — Run the doctor:

```
docker exec -it $(docker ps -aq --filter name=openclaw | head -1) openclaw doctor  
--fix
```

Then restart the container. This catches and fixes config errors, missing files, and permission problems.

Fix 4 — Check the logs for clues:

```
docker logs $(docker ps -aq --filter name=openclaw | head -1) --tail 30
```

Look for error messages. Common ones: **Config invalid** (see Problem 1), **ECONNREFUSED** (gateway didn't start), **EADDRINUSE** (port conflict).

Problem 4

API Credits Ran Out or Rate Limit Hit

Symptoms:

- Agent stops responding or gives blank/empty messages
- Agent was working fine earlier today but suddenly stopped
- No error messages — just silence

What happened:

Your API credits ran out or you hit the rate limit (too many requests too quickly). OpenClaw doesn't show an error message when this happens — the agent just goes quiet.

Fix:

- **Anthropic:** Go to console.anthropic.com → check your credit balance and rate limit tier
- **OpenAI:** Go to platform.openai.com → check your usage and billing
- **OpenRouter:** Go to openrouter.ai/credits → check your balance
- **Google Gemini:** Go to aistudio.google.com → check your quota

If credits are low, add more. If you hit a rate limit, wait a few minutes and try again. You can also switch to a free model as a temporary fix: type **/model** in Telegram and switch to a free option like MiniMax M2.5 via OpenRouter.

Tip: This is the most common reason for an agent going silent, and it's the easiest to miss because there's no error message. Always check your credit balance first before troubleshooting anything else.

Problem 5

Agent Not Responding in Telegram Groups

Symptoms:

- Agent works in DMs but ignores messages in groups
- You tag the agent but it doesn't respond

What happened:

The agent's group policy is set to "allowlist" (default) which means it only responds in groups that are explicitly approved. Or the agent doesn't have admin permissions in the group.

Fix 1 — Make sure the bot is an admin:

Open the group → group info → Edit → Administrators → Add Admin → select your bot → Done.

Fix 2 — Enable group support:

In your DM with the agent, type: *I want to use Telegram groups. Set groupPolicy to "open" and keep requireMention true. Apply the change and restart the gateway.*

Warning: Make sure the agent sets groupPolicy to **"open"** — NOT "denylist". The value "denylist" is not valid and will crash OpenClaw. If the agent suggests "denylist", tell it to use "open" instead. See Problem 1 if this has already happened.

Fix 3 — Fix it via terminal if the agent already crashed:

```
docker exec $(docker ps -aq --filter name=openclaw | head -1) sed -i  
's/"groupPolicy": "[^"]*" / "groupPolicy": "open" /' /data/.openclaw/openclaw.json  
  
docker restart $(docker ps -aq --filter name=openclaw | head -1)
```

Problem 6

Agent Stuck After Restart

Symptoms:

- You ran /restart and the agent never came back
- Agent shows as online but doesn't respond to anything

Fix 1 — Start a new session:

Type **/new** in Telegram. This is the most common fix — the old session got stuck during the restart.

Fix 2 — Restart the container from terminal:

```
docker restart $(docker ps -aq --filter name=openclaw | head -1)
```

Wait a minute, then type **/new** in Telegram, then "hello".

Fix 3 — Full stop and start:

```
docker stop $(docker ps -aq --filter name=openclaw | head -1) && docker start  
$(docker ps -aq --filter name=openclaw | head -1)
```

This does a complete shutdown and fresh start. More thorough than a simple restart.

Problem 7

Gateway Dashboard Won't Load

Symptoms:

- Browser shows "This site can't be reached" or just loads forever
- Dashboard shows "device identity required" error

Fix 1 — Make sure you're using the right URL:

Go to Hostinger → Docker Manager → click **OpenClaw** button next to your project. This opens the correct URL with the right port.

Fix 2 — Check the gateway token:

In Hostinger Docker Manager, click **Gateway token** to copy it. Use this to log into the dashboard.

Fix 3 — "Device identity required" error:

This happens when you access the dashboard over HTTP instead of HTTPS. If you set `allowInsecureAuth` to `true` during the security lesson, this should not appear. If it does, your agent may have changed this setting. Fix it:

```
docker exec $(docker ps -aq --filter name=openclaw | head -1) sed -i  
's/"allowInsecureAuth": false/"allowInsecureAuth": true/'  
/data/.openclaw/openclaw.json  
  
docker restart $(docker ps -aq --filter name=openclaw | head -1)
```

Problem 8

Skill Installation Failed or Skill Not Working

Symptoms:

- Skill installs but doesn't work when you try to use it
- Agent says skill is not found or not installed
- VirusTotal flags the skill as suspicious

Fix 1 — VirusTotal flagged it:

Go to clawhub.ai and check the Security Scan section on the skill's page. If both VirusTotal and the OpenClaw scan show **Benign**, it's safe. Tell your agent to install with **--force**.

Fix 2 — Skill installed but not working:

Some skills need extra setup (like Google OAuth for the GOG skill). Ask your agent: *Is the [skill name] skill fully set up? What else needs to be configured?*

Fix 3 — Reinstall the skill:

Ask your agent: *Uninstall the [skill name] skill and then reinstall it from ClawHub.*

Problem 9

Google Workspace (GOG) OAuth Not Connecting

Symptoms:

- OAuth keeps sending you new URLs in a loop
- "This site can't be reached" after authorising but pasting the URL doesn't work
- Agent says state is lost or auth code expired

What happened:

The OAuth redirect URL uses localhost which doesn't work on a remote VPS because there's no local browser. The agent may also lose state between steps.

Fix:

Tell your agent: *The localhost callback doesn't work because I'm on a remote VPS. Use `http://localhost` as the redirect URI so I can copy the URL from the error page and paste it back.*

When you get the "This site can't be reached" page, copy the **entire URL** from the address bar and paste it into Telegram. Make sure you copy the whole thing including all the parameters after the ?.

If the agent says the code expired, ask for a fresh URL and do the process again quickly — the auth code only lasts a few minutes.

Nuclear Option — Restore From Backup

If nothing above works, you can always restore your server to a previous state:

- Go to Hostinger → VPS Overview → **Snapshot & backups**
- Click **Restore** on the most recent backup from before the problem happened
- Wait for the restore to complete (this can take up to 30 minutes)
- Your agent will be back to exactly how it was at the time of that backup

Warning: Restoring from backup will undo ALL changes made since that backup — not just the one that caused the problem. This includes new skills, conversations, config changes, and memory entries.

How To Prevent Problems

- **Use a strong model for config changes** — cheaper models like Haiku are more likely to guess config values incorrectly and crash OpenClaw. Use Sonnet or better when your agent needs to change any settings.
- **Check what your agent is changing** — if the agent says it's going to update a config value, read what it's proposing. If the value looks unfamiliar, tell the agent to check the OpenClaw docs first.
- **Take snapshots before big changes** — go to Hostinger → Snapshot & backups → Create Snapshot before asking your agent to change settings or install new skills.
- **Check credits regularly** — the most common reason for a silent agent is empty credits. Check your API dashboard every few days.
- **Use /new when things feel stuck** — starting a fresh session solves a surprising number of problems. Make it your first thing to try.
- **Keep OpenClaw updated** — ask your agent to check for updates regularly. Newer versions fix bugs and improve config validation.

Tip: Tell your agent: "Before you make any config changes, show me exactly what you're going to change and wait for my approval." This gives you a chance to check the values before they're applied.